



THE VOICE EXPRESS

The Truth Takes Time.

THE VOICE EXPRESS GAZETTE



POLITICS

“They Don’t Know How to Kill Me”

G.N. Saibaba — professor, disability rights activist, and political prisoner — spent 3,592 days in the solitary confinement of Nagpur Central Jail under UAPA charges before dying on 12th October 2024. A tribute and an account of the draconian legal machinery used to silence him, written from outside the gates of JNU.

BY KANDARP

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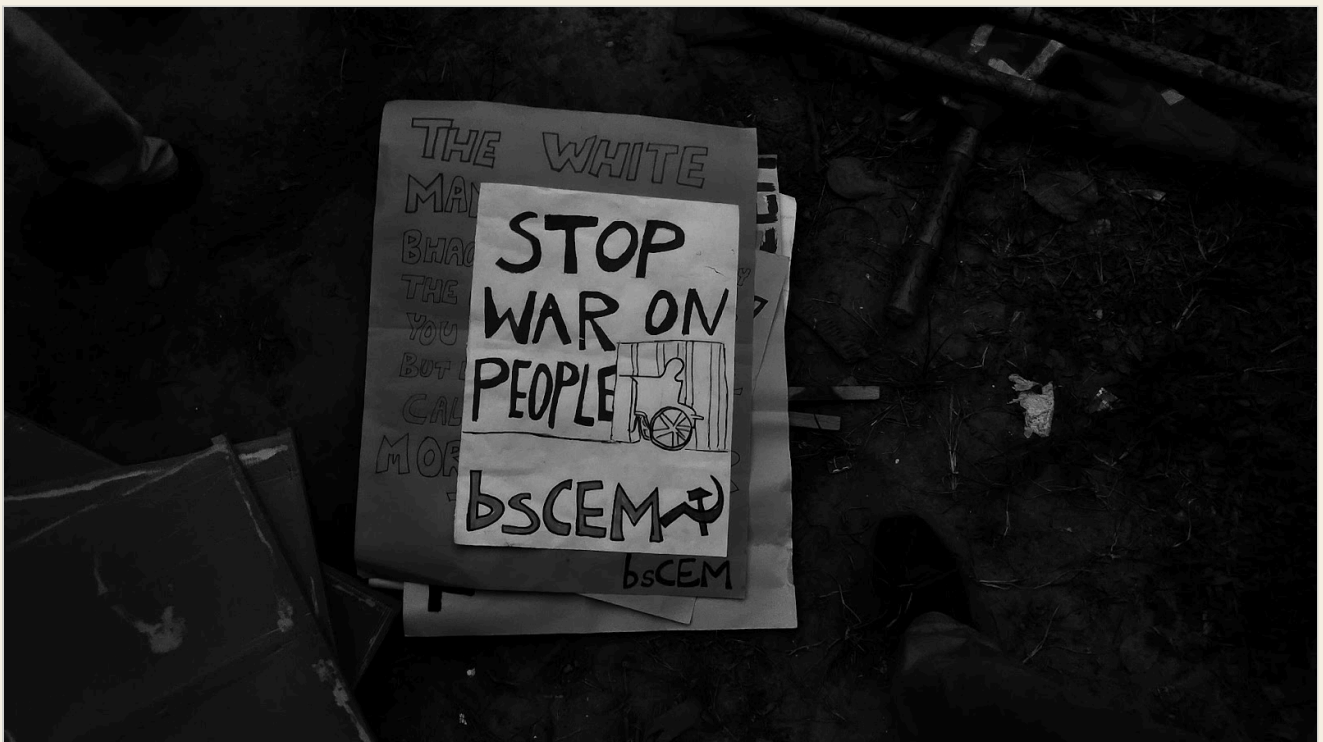
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“You had written, ‘Just like how the state apparatus is sucking the life out of the people and the society, it is squeezing my body dry too. I do not know how much of myself will be left when I leave the prison.’ I too fear the same. Even able-bodied people are not able to endure the harshness of prison life; it must be far worse for you. My biggest concern right now is your health, especially the fact that you have not received any medical treatment in the last four years. Once you wrote to me that you were not sure how long you could survive in these conditions with an abject lack of medical attention. You said that we might hear the news of another Stan Swamy if no treatment is provided to you. Whenever I think of these words, my mind goes to a dark place and a heaviness that does not leave fills my heart.” — January 2022, A.S. Vasantha Kumari, translated from the Telugu by Rajendra Babu Arvini and P. Varalakshmi

The grounds outside JNU's Sabarmati Dhaba have seen many a crowd with raised fists sloganeering for festival, protest, & the mutant cross between the two that is the union election; yesterday, they were raised in grief. G. N. Saibaba 'stubbornly refused to die' for every day of his 3,592-day brutal incarceration since his arrest by the Indian State on the 9th of May 2014, until he couldn't anymore at the age of mere 57. In letters to his wife written from the solitary confinement of his 'anda cell' in Nagpur Central Jail, he once wrote a poem that said, "the sad thing is, they don't know how to kill me." As of 12th October 2024, the sad thing is, they learned.

New Delhi, 14th October 2024: The Unlawful Activities Prevention Act, 1967 (recently amended in 2019 by the incumbent BJP government) is India's primary legislation on 'terrorism.' It is widely regarded as a draconian law in dire need of revisitation because of its use of controversial legal overreaches such as increased investigative prerogatives, lowered guilt criteria, ambiguous language¹, & perhaps most damningly, extended conditions on applying for & receiving bail. In May 2014, a 46-year man was charged under this act & quietly arrested in New Delhi.

The alleged terrorist was handled with appropriate secrecy needed for matters of national security; he was transported discretely to the airport & taken to Nagpur in anti-landmine trucks full of commandos armed with high-tech weaponry, from where more trucks were seen escorting the prisoner to Gadchiroli, where he would be tried². Marathi media quickly reported the big news – a hardcore & dangerous terrorist had been caught, possibly a Maoist leader. This man was DU's beloved & revered professor, 90% disabled & paralyzed from the waist down since a childhood battle with Polio, Dr. Gokarakonda Naga Saibaba.



Saibaba lost the use of his legs when he was only five years old. As his wife & comrade *A. S. Vasantha Kumari* wrote to him through the walls of prison in 2022, 'your legs were motionless, but your hands were your strength.' As he breathed his last at 8:36 on the 12th of October, 2024, Saibaba no longer had the use of his hands. They were taken from him years ago, after his arresting officers threw him into a police car, breaking both his wheelchair & his hands – the first of many abuses they would suffer during his disturbing & inhumane capture. The nerve damage from the fall would later grow into an infection that would render his hands barely usable. While they transported Saibaba to Gadchiroli, his wife was left in the dark. As she

Seven months after his release from the Nagpur Central Jail, where he was falsely incarcerated for over 10 years, on the 12th of October 2024, renowned professor & human rights activist Dr. G. N. Saibaba passed away. The next evening, a small group of people at JNU's iconic Sabarmati Dhaba came together to do something enthusiasm cannot help with – grieve. Photojournalist Kandarp Bhargav's photographs document the necropolitics of not just a disabled academic's institutional murder^[1], but also those of another, quieter one still in progress. It is the murder of the academic apparatus of this country, one which in these photographs is being asked to organize & attend its own wake.



On the banners behind the tennis court where the crowd eventually gathered & in the WhatsApp forward stragglers who'd made up their minds last minute were toting around, the names given to the gathering varied. The big red banner nestled between the communist flags on the hedges called it the 'Red Salute to Comrade G. N. Saibaba.' The forward doing the rounds on people's statuses called it a 'Public Meeting' remembering his legacy. The posters lined on a string stretched across the court read like a protest against the law, but the voices in the crowd sounded hesitant the way they rarely are at those, like they're undecided which of the three they want this to be. Hindu's article the next morning about the event conveniently labeled it a 'tribute by friends, professors & students,' which sounds - if nothing else - nice.

"The event in itself was in solidarity with G.N Saibaba and yet was a protest against the oppression of the authorities and the government. The meeting started with loud hails of anti-fascist sloganeering [which gave the idea of it being a protest]. Eventually, several people gave speeches," Kandarp says, trying to describe the atmosphere of the meeting.

Perhaps, the first stage of grief has always been confusion.



Three days before Saibaba's death from a postoperative complication in a gallbladder surgery, industrialist & chairperson of the multibillion-dollar Tata conglomerate, Ratan N. Tata passed away due to natural causes at the age of 86. People the world over being platformed by national & global media, particularly the government & laypeople of Maharashtra, alongside social media users all across the globe were heartbroken^[2] over his death, with celebrities & politicians flocking either to X (formerly Twitter) or to his state-sponsored last rites in Mumbai to pay him their last respects. G. N. Saibaba's history with Maharashtra & the State is just as rich as Tata's³, but not quite as wholesome. Perhaps that is why the crowd at his makeshift 'funerals' like the one at JNU – or the 'real one'^[3] in Hyderabad – was neither as diverse, as sad, or as newsworthy; nor the queue for it quite as long.



“Ratan Tata was a business person who knew how to deceive struggling low purchasing power people of India, G.N Saibaba [for the government and the masses] was a threat,” says Kandarp, explaining why the sentiments of the masses are more attached to Ratan Tata than activists like Saibaba. “As the state said, ‘Saibaba’s brain is dangerous. His thoughts are dangerous.’ So the mainstream media would never appreciate his struggle and resistance against authoritative oppression.”

The words Kandarp refers to here are those that were used two years ago when news of the reconviction & denial of bail to a 90% disabled professor with a steadily declining physical health after years of imprisonment spread across the country, as the court's justification. “The brain is more dangerous^[4],” said justices M.R. Shah and Bela M. Trivedi in the Supreme Court of India, our highest authority of justice. It is a terrorist's intelligence, not his physical capacity that threatens the ‘unity & sovereignty’ of a country; Saibaba's wheelchair & nerve-damaged fingers were hardly a reason to be careless.

His mind worked fine.



"The community of people grieving him today are the ones who share comradeship and solidarity in the resistance against the oppression of government institutions – activists and professors from different universities who shared close memories of G.N Saibaba. One of them was Hem Mishra." This Hem Mishra, of course, is the JNU student who was among the five others jailed alongside Saibaba in the UAPA "Maoist links" case. Like Saibaba, Mishra was also released from jail & acquitted on all charges in March, more than ten years after he was first arrested.

My fellow
Prisoners,
Don't be agonised,
You'll get free soon.

Written to Sanjay Kak, from the High-Security Prison cell, Nagpur, to the fellow netizen prisoners of the global virtual space, Dr. G. N. Saibaba, 24 March 2018.

After the meeting at Sabarmati, Mishra would leave for Hyderabad, where Saibaba's body rested at his brother's residence before being donated to Telangana's Gandhi Medical College, to pay his last respects to the man he spent a decade with in hell.

The Mahar was taken to Heaven,
and the Chamar to **Hell**.
Both were entrusted
with the holy work
of cleaning the shit of gods
every morning and evening
for life and after-life.
And in the rest of the day,
they have to only clean the sewage.

Written to Vijay Kumar, based on the stories told by two prisoners who spent prison terms for petty crimes, Dr. G. N. Saibaba, 12th April 2018.

"He would say that one day we would walk out of prison," Mishra would recall^[6], at the makeshift funeral. "Because we did nothing wrong. We raised our voices against injustice, for the rights of the people, for the rights of Adivasis, Dalits and all the oppressed in this country. We were, and are, fighting for a just cause," he would say. But Sunday night on the tennis court outside Sabarmati, righteousness did little to soothe anyone's raw conscience.

A man with silver hair & grandpa glasses stood up against the weight of his shaking cane to remind those who'd come to listen of the legacy his friend left behind, one of endurance & resistance against authoritative oppression. A trade union worker described the distinctive empathy of Saibaba's politics, so grass-rooted that it would apply directly to the on-ground

“On my [journey back home], all that hooked me up was the thought of how the government is so afraid of students and such events that they totally record and monitor the spectators and the speakers.” In one of the videos Kandarp took from the meeting, two security guards stand stock still with their hands behind their backs, quietly watching from the boundaries as students chant slogans in memory of Saibaba & his fight against fascism. As the camera hovers over them for more than a second instead of moving past, one of them turns towards it, looking Kandarp in the eye.

Less than a second later, he turns back.



Intimidation & surveillance from campus authorities at protests is far from new phenomena at places like JNU, but Kandarp tells us it is on the rise. “The administration in public universities is restricting any vocal stands from students, be it study circles, meetings, or a protest, and all this has amplified post covid,” he says. “The government is so afraid of students and such events that they totally record and monitor the spectators and the speakers.”



Kandarp also criticizes the NEP for trying to mechanize the education process, conditioning students out of their ability to think critically.

“[They] try to put students in some machine learning structure and want to teach [them] the ideology the center is pleased with: promoting the culture of a certain religion and killing the idea of the secular nation. My experience with professors around Delhi University has been the same.”

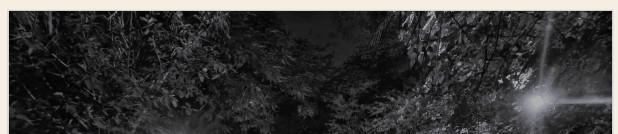
Three years ago, after being arrested under the false Bhima Koregaon conspiracy for which several activists were booked & jailed under the same charges that took away 10 years of Hem Mishra & G. N. Saibaba's lives ('alleged' links to Maoist groups under UAPA), 84 year old tribal rights activist, Father Stan Swamy^[7] passed away while incarcerated as he was denied bail despite being critically diagnosed with Parkinson's. The same was done to Saibaba & his fellow prisoners, of

"You had written, 'Just like how the state apparatus is sucking the life out of the people and the society, it is squeezing my body dry too. I do not know how much of myself will be left when I leave the prison.' I too fear the same. Even able-bodied people are not able to endure the harshness of prison life; it must be far worse for you. My biggest concern right now is your health, especially the fact that you have not received any medical treatment in the last four years. Once you wrote to me that you were not sure how long you could survive in these conditions with an abject lack of medical attention. You said that we might hear the news of another Stan Swamy if no treatment is provided to you. Whenever I think of these words, my mind goes to a dark place and a heaviness that does not leave fills my heart." — January 2022, A.S. Vasantha Kumari, translated from the Telugu by Rajendra Babu Arvini and P. Varalakshmi

As I sat down to edit this photo essay, amidst invitations to DU's own 'Public Meeting' of the same format & subject in the Arts Faculty, Saibaba's institutional & political haven while he taught English at Ram Lal Anand till his unceremonious & insulting removal from the post in 2021 as a result of the war waged on his character by his own country, I found myself stuck on the image of a lone loudspeaker softly echoing the voices of the attendees' organized grief. I thought about asking Kandarp if Saibaba's own voice ever spoke out of that speaker at any point in the meeting, then remembered the circumstance & let it be.



The thought has nagged at me through the writing of this article; a moronic, transhumanist variant of the worthless platitudes we give to each other when people die: they are alive in what they've left behind. Remembering his eulogy for Stephen Hawking – another wheelchair bound genius who chose academic prodigality over hopelessness, & in the end was comparable to Saibaba in little more than silhouette – I couldn't stop imagining his computerised voice speaking gently from that speaker, being reminded everytime of why I already knew the answer to my question. It would be all too easy, for the same reason why it would be much too painful, to pretend he was there on that tennis court by proxy—because it would be akin to pretending he was still alive.



Despite the complete loss of use of his left hand, & near complete loss in his right, G. N. Saibaba would write in prison. Partly for lack of choice; after the state of Maharashtra reinstated jail mulakats post the covid-19 pandemic, all phone calls were stopped. This was only a formal seal on what was already a black box of communication in the form of Nagpur Central Jail, psychologically tormenting prisoners & their families by withholding news of even their medical conditions. But even when his letters had little hope of reaching their intended address, & even though by the end of the decade it would take him 2-3 days to complete a single page of writing because of the deteriorating state of his hand, Saibaba wrote.

He wrote letters to his family, though he was denied even doing that in his mother tongue, & each letter either way had to be arduously translated. He wrote back & forth to his wife, a bastardized memory of their youth where they exchanged pages upon pages of their young, hopeful love. He wrote to the court, afraid for his life in a prison that locked him up like an animal & forced him to beg for life-saving drugs & the dignity of not having to drag himself around by his elbows. He wrote to fictional characters & his students & colleagues to remind them where the real prison was; in our own moral decrepitude. He wrote to his friends^[10].

Through excruciating pain, he never stopped writing. On October 26th 2017, in a letter to his wife, Saibaba wrote a poem remembering the October revolution in Russia a hundred years prior. It is this poem that opens the collection of his writings from prison which came out of it two years before he did, titled, '*Why Do You Fear My Way So Much?*'^[11]⁶ The title calls on the reader the same, absurd association with Saibaba's shaking pen that the mainstream media tried to purport 8 years prior when he was first captured: fear.

But Saibaba was never the mastermind they were so intent on having us, asininely, believe. He wrote poetry on art & justice & blades of grass, and remembered the dates in history books. He was an English teacher, till the end, & his only crime was an undying smile & refusing to die when he was asked to.

Infuriated by my undying smile,
they captured me again.

I still stubbornly refuse to die.
The sad thing is that
they don't know how to kill me,
because I love so much
the sounds of growing grass.

Written to Vasantha, remembering the October Uprising of 1917, G. N. Saibaba, 26th October 2017.



In a pixellated, zoomed-in still from Kandarp's collection, his lens struggles to get a clean shot of three posters in a line behind the silver-haired speaker's head. The first of them reads a slightly different version of the line – transformed either in translation or memory: 'they don't know how to make me die.' I mull over the eccentricities of meaning & semantics, & my mind wanders back to the loudspeaker. To the speeches & interviews & papers, to the people and the places, and the book full of prison poetry he's left behind. As of 12th October 2024, the state certainly figured out how to kill him, the way it killed Stan Swamy & Pandu Narote, & the way it is killing its own academia^[12] as we watch it happen. But maybe, it is worth believing, that it will never figure out how to make him die.

Kandarp is a 23-year-old journalism undergrad at the University of Delhi. Hailing from eastern UP. Kandarp is passionate about photography and filmmaking. He uses his art to address social issues, & currently works as an independent photographer. He & his work can be found @kandarpbhargav on Instagram.

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SOURCES & REFERENCES

[1] institutional murder

[2] heartbroken

[3] real one

[4] The brain is more dangerous

[5] limited to your opinion

[6] would recall

[7] Father Stan Swamy

[8] Pandu Narote

[9] judicial & extrajudicial apparatus

[10] wrote to his friends

[11] Why Do You Fear My Way So Much?

[12] its own academia